

David Hume (1711–1776)

David Hume was one of the most influential British philosophers and economists of the 18th century. He entered Edinburgh University at the age of 12, and later lived in Paris and London before returning to Edinburgh. A prolific writer, he argued that economic freedom is essential for political freedom. He also showed that prices in a country alter with changes to its supply of money. Limiting imports and encouraging exports doesn't increase a country's wealth. Instead, as exports increase and more gold flows into the country to pay for them, prices for goods in that country actually rise.

William Jevons (1835–1882)

British economist William Jevons was a prolific writer on logic and economics. He showed that a commodity's value depends on its utility to the consumer, not on the cost of producing it. His idea of "marginal utility" explains consumer behavior. You enjoy the last chocolate you eat less than the first. The utility (value) of each extra chocolate—its marginal utility—decreases, so you'll only buy more if the price falls, or you'll buy a different product to get more utility.

[Daniel Kahneman 1934– \(and Amos Tversky 1937–1996\)](#)

[John Maynard Keynes \(1883–1946\)](#)

Paul Krugman (1953–)

US economist Paul Krugman is known for his pioneering work in international trade and finance and for his analysis of currency crises and fiscal (tax) policy. In 2008 he won the Nobel Prize for his study of international trade patterns, which is now known as new trade theory and places geography at the center of economics. He showed that the location of economic activity is driven by consumers' preference for a diverse choice of brands, producers' economies of scale, and the cost of transporting goods.

Arthur Laffer (1940–)

Laffer was one of a group of US economists who, in the 1970s, recommended less government interference with companies supplying goods and services. He is best known for the "Laffer curve," a graph of the relationship between tax rates and how much money they raise, which shows that increasing taxes beyond a certain level means the government may get less revenue.

Christine Lagarde (1956–)

Born in Paris, France, Christine Lagarde originally studied law and worked for an international firm of lawyers before following a career in politics. She became the French Minister of Commerce and Industry in 2005, and was later appointed as the Minister of Finance. In 2011, she was elected Managing Director of the International Monetary Fund.

Thomas Malthus (1766–1834)